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Hot shot: Declan Rice (left) took centre stage with two stunning goals against Real Madrid at the Emirates Stadium, becoming the first player ever to score a brace through free-kicks in UCL knockouts. AP



SHOCK AND AWE

Arsenal ended Real Madrid's love affair with the UCL, while Manchester United lit up Old Trafford with an **unforgettable victory** over Lyon in the Europa League.

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The 2024–25 season of the UEFA Champions League (UCL) featured a new format with more teams and, expectedly, more chatter about the success of more matches and a packed schedule. All of that went out the window in the quarterfinals, with each of the eight matches turning out to be blockbusters — especially the clash between defending champion Real Madrid and Arsenal.

Mikel Arteta's army completed a double over Los Blancos, denying them a semifinal spot in the continental tournament for the first time in five years. And the central figure over the home and away fixtures was England midfielder Declan Rice. Rice took centre stage with two stunning goals at the Emirates Stadium — becoming the first player ever to score a brace through free-kicks in UCL knockouts — in a 3-0 win in the first leg.

In the return leg, Rice donned the robes of a disciplined

midfielder, marking Kylian Mbappe tightly at the Santiago Bernabeu, as the Gunners qualified for the semifinals after 16 years, knocking Madrid out with a 5-1 win on aggregate.

They will face Mbappe's former side, Paris Saint-Germain, in the semifinals, which reached consecutive semis under manager Luis Enrique, this time with a 5-4 win on aggregate over Aston Villa. Though Villa struck thrice in the return leg, an astute final 30 minutes by the French side helped